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Civil War-Induced Displacement and Human Capital

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1 Big picture

1.1 Central question

The paper asks how civil-war-induced displacement affects long-run human capital and occupational outcomes. The empirical setting is the Mozambican civil war, which displaced roughly one-third of the surviving population. The question is not simply whether displacement is harmful or beneficial. The paper asks how effects vary across displacement trajectories, age of move, origin and destination characteristics, and postwar reintegration.

1.2 Main empirical contribution

- The paper reconstructs wartime mobility using the 1997 Mozambique population census.
- It separates externally displaced refugees, rural-to-rural IDPs, rural-to-urban IDPs, urban-to-rural movers, and urban-to-urban movers.
- It studies both human-capital outcomes and occupational structure: primary completion, years of schooling, agricultural employment, and service employment.
- It combines three research designs: cross-sectional trajectory comparisons, within-household comparisons among separated relatives, and movers designs based on age at displacement.
- It supplements census evidence with a 2020 survey in Nampula that measures trust, social capital, civic attitudes, optimism, loneliness, and mental health.

1.3 Headline results

- Forced displacement is associated with higher schooling, especially for rural-born children displaced to urban areas.
- Rural-to-rural internal displacement also raises schooling relative to rural nonmovers, even when the destination is not obviously better.
- External displacement is less positive, consistent with refugee-camp restrictions, uncertain schooling quality, limited labor opportunities, and psychosocial stress.
- Urban-born displaced to rural areas often experience negative place effects because their destinations have lower schooling levels than their origins.
- Occupational effects are modest but meaningful: rural-to-urban IDPs shift away from agriculture and toward services.
- Survey evidence shows that displaced people can have educational gains while experiencing lower trust, lower optimism, and worse mental health.

1.4 Core mechanisms

The paper organizes mechanisms into three components.

1. **Place effects.** Displacement can move children to districts with better schools, lower agricultural dependence, and better exposure to nonagricultural work.
2. **Spatial sorting.** Families that move to better places may differ from families that move to worse places or stay behind. Sorting may reflect networks, wealth, ability, ambition, risk tolerance, or wartime survival strategies.

3. **Uprootedness/disruption.** Displacement itself can change incentives by destroying local land-based assets, weakening attachment to agriculture, or making portable human capital more valuable. This component may raise schooling even when the destination is not a high-opportunity urban area.

1.5 Interpretive caution

The paper does not claim that war is good. The result is more subtle: forced displacement can reallocate some children toward higher-schooling environments or toward investments in portable human capital. But these gains coexist with violence, death, trauma, separation, insecurity, and long-run psychosocial costs. The policy conclusion is therefore not to view displacement as beneficial, but to understand how destination conditions and reintegration policies can mitigate harm and preserve human-capital opportunities.

2 Historical background, data, and measurement

2.1 Mozambican civil war and displacement trajectories

- Mozambique’s civil war lasted from 1977 to 1992 and involved severe rural violence, forced movement, destruction of infrastructure, and large refugee flows.
- Displacement trajectories differed dramatically: some civilians fled abroad, some moved from rural areas to cities, some moved from rural to rural districts, and some urban-born individuals were pushed into rural areas.
- Refugees abroad often lived in camps or settlements with limited labor-market opportunities, though some had access to humanitarian schooling.
- Rural-to-urban IDPs moved into cities and towns that had functioning schools and more service-sector work, even though urban living conditions were difficult.
- Rural-to-rural IDPs often moved to areas with weak infrastructure, insecurity, and limited opportunities, yet the paper still finds positive education effects for many of them.

Detailed interpretation: The paper treats displacement as a set of heterogeneous mobility shocks rather than a single binary treatment. This is essential because the same war can send different children into radically different human-capital environments.

2.2 1997 census

The 1997 census is the empirical backbone. It records birthplace, location at the end of the war in 1992, and residence in 1997. It also records education, employment sector, age, gender, language, religion, household composition, and other characteristics. The paper uses these data to identify people born before the end of the war and to classify their wartime displacement trajectories.

- **Non-displaced:** individuals residing in their district of birth in 1992.
- **Externally displaced/refugees:** individuals residing outside Mozambique in 1992.
- **Internally displaced:** individuals residing in a Mozambican district other than the district of birth in 1992.
- **Rural/urban origin:** based on census classifications of birth districts and urban localities.
- **Main age group:** individuals aged 12–32 in 1997, whose schooling decisions were exposed to the war period.

Detailed interpretation: The census is valuable because it gives near-universe coverage, but it also has limitations. It observes survivors in 1997, not all people displaced during the war. It reconstructs displacement from residence in 1992 and 1997, not complete yearly trajectories. The paper’s designs are built around these strengths and limitations.

2.3 Outcome variables

- **Completed primary school:** a binary indicator for completing primary education.
- **Years of schooling:** a continuous measure of educational attainment.
- **Agricultural employment:** indicator for employment in agriculture.
- **Service employment:** indicator for employment in services.
- **Upper-primary completion:** used in the Nampula survey and sibling analysis.
- **Social and mental-health outcomes:** trust, social capital, civic attitudes, loneliness, optimism, and mental health index.

Detailed interpretation: Schooling outcomes capture portable human capital. Employment outcomes show whether displacement moves people out of agriculture. Survey outcomes capture welfare dimensions absent from the census.

2.4 Separated extended-family sample

This sample contains extended family members aged 12–32 in 1997 who lived in the same postwar household but had different wartime displacement trajectories as minors. The household fixed-effect design compares relatives who share postwar household environment and many background characteristics.

- It includes siblings, cousins, nieces, nephews, and other extended relatives.
- It requires at least one member displaced as a minor between 1975 and 1992.
- It compares people in the same 1997 household, absorbing household-level preferences, networks, resources, and postwar location.
- It is especially useful for rural-born relatives where some stayed, some moved to rural districts, and some moved to cities.

Detailed interpretation: This design reduces, but does not eliminate, selection concerns. Relatives may still differ in unobserved traits, birth order, or exposure to violence. But it is much stronger than comparing all displaced and nondisplaced individuals across the country.

2.5 Movers design

The movers design focuses on internally displaced minors and uses age at move to estimate childhood regional exposure effects. The key idea is that moving earlier to a district with higher nonmover human capital should have a larger effect on schooling than moving later.

- Destination-origin difference in human capital is measured using nonmovers from the same birth cohort.
- The design interacts the destination-origin difference with age at displacement.
- The coefficients before age 15 are interpreted as childhood exposure effects for primary schooling.
- The coefficients after age 15 are interpreted mostly as spatial sorting because primary schooling decisions are largely completed by then.

Detailed interpretation: The age-at-move gradient is a powerful way to distinguish place effects from selection. If the destination difference only reflects sorting, it should not matter much whether a child moved at age 5 or age 17. If childhood exposure matters, earlier movers should be more affected.

2.6 Nampula survey

The authors conducted a 2020 survey in Nampula. It compares displaced Nampula residents with siblings who stayed behind and with urban-born nonmovers. The survey is much smaller than the census, but it measures outcomes not available in administrative data.

- Education: upper-primary completion.
- Social trust: willingness to trust neighbors and sense of belonging.
- Social capital: willingness to contribute to community projects and exchange favors.
- Civic attitudes: attitudes toward taxes, bribes, and benefits.
- Psychological outcomes: loneliness, optimism, and mental health based on a PHQ-9-type module.

Detailed interpretation: The survey adds an important welfare nuance: human-capital gains need not imply overall welfare gains. Displacement may raise schooling and still damage trust, social integration, and mental health.

3 Models and empirical specifications

3.1 Cross-sectional displacement-trajectory specification

The baseline descriptive model is

$$Y_i = \alpha + \sum_j \beta_j \text{Trajectory}_{ij} + X_i' \Gamma + \delta_{birth} + \lambda_{cohort} + \varepsilon_i.$$

Here Y_i is an education or employment outcome, Trajectory_{ij} identifies displacement trajectory, X_i includes individual controls, δ_{birth} are district-of-birth fixed effects, and λ_{cohort} are cohort fixed effects.

Detailed interpretation: This model compares individuals born in the same districts and cohorts but following different wartime trajectories. It is useful for mapping the universe of effects, but it remains vulnerable to selection into displacement.

3.2 Within-household specification

The household fixed-effect model is

$$Y_{ih} = \alpha + \sum_j \beta_j \text{Trajectory}_{ij} + X_i' \Gamma + \eta_h + \lambda_{cohort} + \varepsilon_{ih}.$$

The fixed effect η_h compares extended family members who live in the same 1997 household.

Detailed interpretation: This specification is closer to a family-level natural experiment. It absorbs household preferences, resources, family networks, religion, ethnicity, and postwar location. If positive rural IDP effects survive this design, they are harder to explain by broad family sorting.

3.3 Movers age-at-exposure design

For movers, the paper estimates age-specific effects of destination-origin human-capital differences:

$$Y_{iodm} = \alpha + \sum_m \gamma_m [\Delta y_{od,b} \times 1\{AgeMove_i = m\}] + \eta_{o,m} + \psi_d + X_i' \Gamma + \varepsilon_i.$$

$\Delta y_{od,b}$ is the destination-minus-origin difference in human capital among nonmovers of the same birth cohort. The coefficients γ_m show how much this place difference matters when the child moves at age m .

Detailed interpretation: The expected pattern is downward-sloping with age: younger children should absorb more of the destination environment. Estimates after age 15 are interpreted as selection because primary education is mostly fixed by then.

3.4 Joint mechanism specification

The joint specification includes displacement, place effects, and age-window interactions:

$$Y_i = \beta Displaced_i + \sum_w \gamma_w [\Delta y_{od,b} \times 1\{AgeWindow_i = w\}] + X_i' \Gamma + FE + \varepsilon_i.$$

The coefficient β is interpreted as uprootedness/disruption after controlling for measured destination-origin differences and sorting.

Detailed interpretation: This equation is central for separating mechanisms. The destination-origin interactions capture place exposure and spatial sorting. The displaced indicator captures residual effects of being uprooted, including changed incentives to invest in schooling or disruption of land-based livelihoods.

3.5 Instrumental-variable approach

The paper uses prewar migration networks as instruments for destination choices in some specifications. The logic is that historical links between origin and destination predict where people flee, but plausibly shift schooling mainly through wartime destination exposure conditional on controls.

Detailed interpretation: The IV is designed to address sorting on unobservables in destination choice. It is not the only identification strategy; it complements household fixed effects and conflict-window restrictions.

3.6 Survey regressions

Survey specifications compare IDPs in Nampula to two groups:

- siblings who stayed behind in rural origins;
- urban-born Nampula residents who never moved.

The regressions control for age, gender, and indicators such as eldest-offspring status.

Detailed interpretation: The survey evidence is more suggestive than the census evidence because the sample is smaller and geographically concentrated. Its strength is the measurement of social and psychological outcomes.

4 Identification and empirical design

4.1 Why cross-sectional comparisons are not enough

Cross-sectional estimates compare people with different displacement histories. These estimates are important because they describe the entire population, but they can confound displacement with selection. Families who flee abroad, move to cities, move to rural areas, or stay may differ in wealth, networks, access to information, political connections, or exposure to violence.

4.2 Why within-household comparisons help

The household fixed-effect design compares relatives living in the same household in 1997. This absorbs many family-level confounders:

- family preferences for education;
- postwar household resources;
- ethnicity, religion, and language;
- household head characteristics;
- postwar local labor-market conditions.

Detailed interpretation: The design is strongest when relatives faced plausibly different displacement opportunities because of wartime shocks, age, or household splitting rather than because of individual ability. It still cannot rule out all within-family selection, such as birth-order differences or strategic evacuation of particular children.

4.3 Why conflict timing matters

The paper restricts some estimates to moves occurring in the same year, within one year, or within two years of major conflict events in the birthplace. This makes ordinary economic migration less likely and war-induced displacement more likely.

Detailed interpretation: Timing restrictions strengthen the claim that moves were forced or induced by conflict. If results remain under tight conflict windows, they are harder to explain by ordinary migration toward better schools or jobs.

4.4 Age-at-move as an exposure design

The movers design uses the fact that children moving earlier should be more affected by the destination environment. The design exploits variation in age at move while comparing destination-origin differences measured among nonmovers. It separates:

- childhood exposure: younger movers benefit or suffer more from the destination environment;
- spatial sorting: older movers reflect selection rather than exposure;
- origin effects: absorbed through birth-origin-by-age fixed effects in some specifications.

Detailed interpretation: The key visual diagnostic is Figure IV. A stronger relationship for young movers than older movers supports a childhood place-effect interpretation.

4.5 Sorting and IV

Spatial sorting remains a concern even within movers. Families with more resources or stronger networks may reach better destinations. The paper addresses this in three ways:

1. comparing relatives with household fixed effects;
2. tightening the conflict window;
3. instrumenting destination choice with prewar migration networks.

Detailed interpretation: No one design is perfect. The paper’s credibility comes from triangulation: cross-sectional results, household fixed effects, movers exposure, conflict-window restrictions, and IV estimates all point in related directions.

4.6 Survey evidence and its role

The Nampula survey is not the primary identification design. Its role is to add long-run outcomes missing from the census. The survey shows that education gains can coexist with lower trust, lower civiness, lower optimism, loneliness, and worse mental health.

Detailed interpretation: This changes the welfare interpretation. A narrow schooling outcome can look positive while overall displacement welfare remains deeply negative.

4.7 Remaining threats

- Census survivorship may exclude those who died during or soon after the war.
- The census observes location in 1992 and 1997, not full annual mobility.
- Household composition in 1997 may be endogenous to postwar family reunification.
- Destination-origin differences may reflect unobserved factors beyond schooling environments.
- The survey is small and concentrated in Nampula.

5 Section-by-section study guide

5.1 Introduction

The introduction motivates the paper by pointing to contemporary displacement crises and the scarcity of large-scale causal evidence on human-capital consequences. It frames the key puzzle: forced displacement is destructive, yet it may shift some children into better schooling environments or change incentives toward portable human capital.

5.2 Historical background and data

This section explains Mozambique’s war, displacement trajectories, and the 1997 census. The key reading task is to understand why refugees, rural-to-urban IDPs, rural-to-rural IDPs, and urban-to-rural movers are separate treatments. The maps in Figure I are essential for seeing spatial heterogeneity.

5.3 Cross-sectional estimates

This section describes the broad association between displacement trajectories and education/employment. Table II is the core object. It shows the size of effects before deeper identification designs.

5.4 Separated households

This section introduces the within-household design. Table III describes the sample and Figure III maps where separated households come from. Table IV reports the results. This section is the main response to family-level selection concerns.

5.5 Movers design

This section estimates regional childhood exposure effects. Figure IV is the key visual. It shows whether moving earlier to a better destination matters more than moving later, which supports the place-effect mechanism.

5.6 Joint mechanisms

Figure V and Table V combine the mechanisms: destination-origin differences, sorting, IV, and residual displacement. This is the most synthetic part of the paper.

5.7 Survey evidence

Tables VI and VII add a long-run welfare perspective. The survey asks whether human-capital gains persist and whether displacement damages trust, optimism, and mental health.

6 Tables and figures

6.1 Table I: Refugees, IDPs, and Non-Movers + Figure I: Displacement by District of Birth

Read:

- Table I shows that among all people older than five in 1997, 7% were refugees, 21% were internally displaced, and 72% were non-displaced.
- Among individuals aged 12–32, the shares are similar: 6% refugees, 21% IDPs, and 72% non-displaced.
- In the separated-household sample, IDPs are overrepresented: 52% are internally displaced, reflecting the design’s focus on households with separated minors.
- The movers-analysis sample is entirely internally displaced minors, with roughly two-thirds rural-born and one-third urban-born.
- Figure I maps displacement rates by rural birth district. Refugee displacement is concentrated near borders; rural-to-rural displacement is concentrated in interior conflict zones; rural-to-urban displacement is strongest near cities and towns.

Detailed interpretation: Table I defines the empirical universe and clarifies which samples are used for which designs. Figure I shows why trajectory-specific analysis is necessary: displacement is not evenly spread across space, and different origin districts feed into different types of displacement. The spatial heterogeneity means that simply comparing displaced and nondisplaced people can mix multiple treatments.

Economic message: The data are large enough to study many displacement paths separately, and the geography already suggests different mechanisms: camps, rural refuge, and urban schooling access are distinct economic environments.

TABLE I
REFUGEES, IDPS, AND NON-MOVERS

	Full sample		Sample 12–32		Separated HHs		Movers analysis		Extended	
	Observations	Prop.	Observations	Prop.	Observations	Prop.	Observations	Prop.	Observations	Prop.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
Refugees	749,416	0.07	363,557	0.06	5,324	0.05	0	0.00	0	0.00
Born abroad	159,123	0.21	53,824	0.15	9	0.00	0	—	0	—
Refugee, rural	527,603	0.70	275,332	0.76	4,492	0.84	0	—	0	—
Refugee, urban	62,690	0.08	34,601	0.10	832	0.16	0	—	0	—
Internally displaced	2,431,551	0.21	1,191,273	0.21	58,537	0.52	310,079	1.00	272,124	0.57
Internally displaced, rural	1,755,829	0.72	848,834	0.71	40,295	0.69	210,148	0.68	182,180	0.67
Internally displaced, urban	675,722	0.28	342,439	0.29	18,242	0.31	99,931	0.32	90,931	0.33
Non-displaced	8,300,267	0.72	4,071,085	0.72	48,873	0.43	0	0.00	208,529	0.43
Non-displaced, rural	6,280,931	0.76	3,006,824	0.74	28,900	0.59	0	—	98,381	0.47
Non-displaced, urban	2,019,336	0.24	1,064,261	0.26	19,973	0.41	0	—	110,148	0.53
Total	11,481,234		5,625,915		112,734		310,079		480,653	

Notes: The table reports the number and the share of refugees (externally displaced), internally displaced, and non-displaced individuals as recorded in the 1997 census. In each category, we distinguish between individuals born in rural districts and urban localities, using the census classification. Columns (1) and (2) show the tabulation for the full sample of individuals older than five years in 1997. Columns (3) and (4) focus on individuals aged 12–32 in 1997, and columns (5) and (6) report the sample of extended family members (siblings, cousins, relatives) aged 12–32 in 1997 in households with at least one member displaced as a minor in the period 1975–1992. Columns (7) and (8) present tabulations for the movers-design sample, comprising all internally displaced individuals who were 0–15 years old at the time of displacement between 1975 and 1992. Columns (9) and (10) extend the movers’ sample to include the 12–32-year-old non-displaced members of their households (if there are any).

(a) Table I: Refugees, IDPs, and Non-Movers

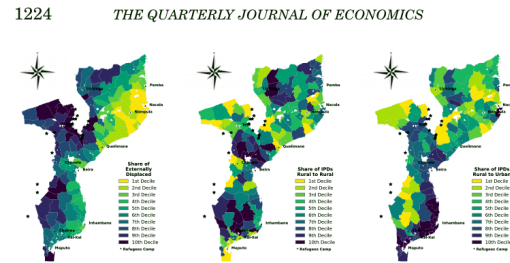


FIGURE I
Displacement by District of Birth

(b) Figure I: Displacement by District of Birth

6.2 Figure II: Displacement and Conflict at the Time of Move

Read:

- Panel A shows that a large share of moves occurs in conflict windows around major conflict events.
- Panel B decomposes timing by trajectory: external displacement, rural-to-rural, rural-to-urban, urban-to-rural, and urban-to-urban moves.
- Rural-born displacement is especially tied to conflict timing.
- The figure also reveals that not every move occurs exactly in a conflict year, motivating robustness windows of same year, plus/minus one year, and plus/minus two years.

Detailed interpretation: Figure II is an identification figure. It links reported moves to conflict events and makes the case that the paper is studying war-induced displacement rather than ordinary migration. The variation across trajectories is also informative: some paths are more likely to be direct flight from violence, while others may include secondary movement or postwar return.

Economic message: The timing evidence supports treating displacement as a shock to location and opportunity rather than a standard household migration choice.

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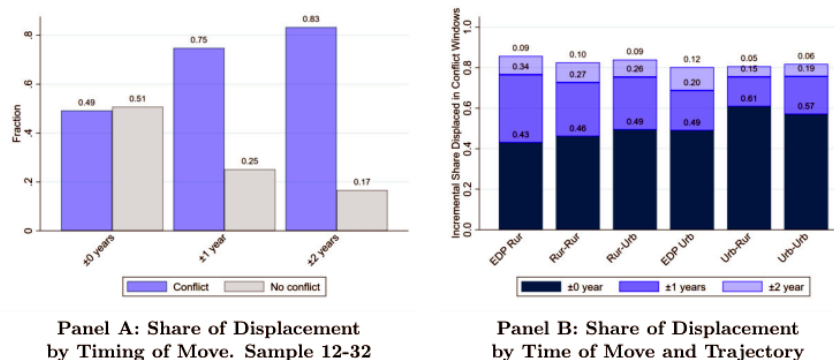


FIGURE II

Figure II: Displacement and Conflict at the Time of Move

6.3 Table II: Displacement Trajectories, Schooling, and Employment: Cross-Sectional Estimates

Read:

- For rural-born individuals, rural-to-urban internal displacement generates large gains in primary completion and years of schooling.
- Rural-to-rural internal displacement also has positive schooling coefficients, although smaller than rural-to-urban moves.
- External displacement is less favorable and sometimes negative, consistent with refugee restrictions and difficult camp conditions.
- For urban-born individuals, moving to rural destinations can reduce education and shift employment toward agriculture.
- Employment effects mirror education effects: rural-to-urban movers become less agricultural and more service-oriented.

Detailed interpretation: Table II is the first quantitative result table. It is cross-sectional, so it is not the final causal design, but it shows the major empirical patterns. The table demonstrates that displacement is not a uniform treatment. The same civil war created upward mobility for some rural children and downward environmental exposure for some urban children.

Economic message: The gains from displacement depend strongly on destination. Urban exposure and nonagricultural opportunities can turn a traumatic move into a schooling gain, while refugee and rural

destinations may offer fewer opportunities.

TABLE II
DISPLACEMENT TRAJECTORIES, SCHOOLING, AND EMPLOYMENT: CROSS-SECTIONAL ESTIMATES

	Compl. primary (dummy)		Years of schooling		Agriculture employment		Service employment	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Panel A: Born rural								
Externally displaced	-0.021*** (0.003)	-0.003 (0.006)	-0.253*** (0.026)	0.042 (0.054)	0.002* (0.001)	-0.013* (0.007)	-0.006*** (0.002)	0.001 (0.003)
Intern. displ. rural → urban	0.296*** (0.021)	0.243*** (0.016)	2.215*** (0.162)	1.844*** (0.130)	-0.395*** (0.039)	-0.332*** (0.028)	0.308*** (0.031)	0.268*** (0.024)
Intern. displ. rural → rural	0.075*** (0.010)	0.069*** (0.014)	0.589*** (0.071)	0.581*** (0.099)	-0.070*** (0.010)	-0.056*** (0.012)	0.052*** (0.007)	0.043*** (0.009)
Mean omitted	0.128	0.128	1.488	1.488	0.918	0.918	0.042	0.042
Observations	4,184,614	4,184,614	4,184,614	4,184,614	2,712,014	2,712,014	2,712,014	2,712,014
No. of households	2,282,749	2,282,749	2,282,749	2,282,749	1,730,975	1,730,975	1,730,975	1,730,975
No. cluster admin-2 birth	129	129	129	129	129	129	129	129
No. cluster admin-2 res92	219	219	219	219	219	219	219	219
Panel B: Born urban								
Externally displaced	-0.209*** (0.020)	-0.075*** (0.015)	-1.684*** (0.162)	-0.527*** (0.109)	0.247*** (0.061)	0.064*** (0.023)	-0.193*** (0.052)	-0.058*** (0.020)
Intern. displ. urban → rural	-0.095** (0.042)	-0.084*** (0.032)	-0.690** (0.289)	-0.562** (0.220)	0.174** (0.087)	0.173** (0.068)	-0.133** (0.067)	-0.135** (0.056)
Intern. displ. urban → urban	0.138*** (0.005)	0.150*** (0.029)	1.041*** (0.000)	1.283*** (0.235)	-0.262*** (0.015)	-0.230*** (0.051)	0.223*** (0.014)	0.202*** (0.048)

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TABLE II
CONTINUED

	Compl. primary (dummy)		Years of schooling		Agriculture employment		Service employment	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Mean omitted	0.412	0.412	3.653	3.653	0.572	0.572	0.298	0.298
Observations	1,441,301	1,441,301	1,441,301	1,441,301	579,307	579,307	579,307	579,307
No. of households	722,416	722,416	722,416	722,416	410,117	410,117	410,117	410,117
Omitted category	Non-displ.	Non-displ.	Non-displ.	Non-displ.	Non-displ.	Non-displ.	Non-displ.	Non-displ.
Controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
District of birth fixed effects	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
No. cluster admin-2 birth	90	90	90	90	90	90	90	90
No. cluster admin-2 res92	219	219	219	219	218	218	218	218

Notes: The table reports estimates associating schooling and employment outcomes with various displacement trajectories for individuals aged 12–52 in 1997. The dependent variable in columns (1) and (2) is an indicator variable that takes the value of one for individuals who have completed primary school and were otherwise. The dependent variable in columns (3) and (4) is an indicator variable that takes the value of one for employment in agriculture and the service sector and were otherwise. Binary outcome estimates also control for a gender indicator, an indicator for the eldest child of the household head, age fixed effects, and district of birth controls. Panel A shows trajectories for rural-born Mozambicans, and Panel B shows urban-born Mozambicans. The externally displaced indicator identifies those who in 1992 resided in neighboring countries; the category includes those born in rural areas in Mozambique or those born in neighboring countries. IDP B-E is an indicator that takes the value of one for rural-born individuals who resided in 1992 in urban regions and were otherwise. IDP B-R is an indicator that takes the value of one for rural-born individuals who in 1992 resided in a rural region other than their region of birth and were otherwise. IDP U-B is an indicator that takes the value of one for urban-born individuals who resided in 1992 in rural regions and were otherwise. IDP U-U is an indicator that takes the value of one for urban-born individuals residing in an urban area that is not their urban district of birth. The omitted category in Panel A is rural-born Mozambicans residing in the same district in 1992, and the omitted category in Panel B is urban-born Mozambicans residing in the same district in 1992. The rural-urban classification follows the 1997 Mozambican census. Heteroskedasticity-adjusted standard errors clustered on two dimensions (admin-2 district level of birth and admin-2 district level of residence in 1992) are reported in parentheses. * $p < .10$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$.

6.4 Table III: Households with Separated Extended Family Members: Displacement Trajectories (Birth Districts) + Figure III: Households with Separated Extended Family Members by District of Birth

Read:

- Table III describes households with separated extended family members and reports how relatives split across displacement trajectories.
- The most common category is rural nonmovers combined with rural IDPs, followed by urban nonmovers with urban IDPs.
- Figure III maps the number and share of households with separated extended family members across birth districts.
- Regions affected by the conflict have more households with displaced children, consistent with the design's link to war exposure.

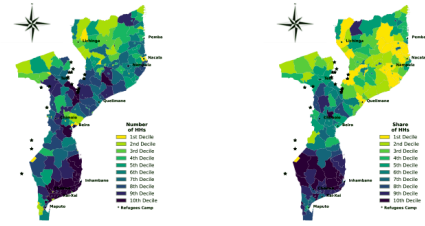
Detailed interpretation: Table III and Figure III define the within-household identification sample. This is not a representative sample of all households; it is a sample designed to compare relatives who ended up in the same household after following different wartime paths. The map helps show that these separated households arise in conflict-relevant regions, supporting the design.

Economic message: Separated families provide a powerful comparison because they hold fixed many family-level traits that usually confound migration and education outcomes.

TABLE III
HOUSEHOLDS WITH SEPARATED EXTENDED FAMILY MEMBERS: DISPLACEMENT TRAJECTORIES (BIRTH DISTRICTS)

Categories (birth district)	Individuals	Percentage	Extended households	Percentage
NM rural + IDP rural	36,826	32.67	10,861	35.09
NM urban + IDP urban	17,776	15.77	4,772	15.42
IDP rural only	7,486	6.64	2,636	8.52
NM rural + NM urban + IDP rural	9,226	8.18	1,964	6.34
NM rural + EDP	4,182	3.71	1,376	4.45
NM urban + IDP rural	4,813	4.27	1,337	4.32
IDP (R+U) only	3,233	2.87	1,074	3.47
NM urban + IDPs (R+U)	5,134	4.55	1,038	3.35
NM rural + IDPs (R+U)	4,820	4.28	1,025	3.31
NM rural + IDP urban	2,459	2.18	783	2.53
IDP urban only	2,105	1.87	773	2.50
NM rural + NM urban + IDP urban	3,025	2.68	687	2.22
IDP rural + EDP	2,142	1.90	685	2.21
Other categories	9,507	8.43	1,842	6.27
Total	112,734		30,950	

Notes: The table describes the different trajectories of extended family members (siblings, cousins, relatives) aged 12–12 in 1997 in households with at least one member displaced as a minor in 1975–1982. The table provides the number of individuals and households for each trajectory.



Panel A: Separated Household Panel B: Separated Household Share

FIGURE III

(a) Table III: Households with Separated Extended Family Members

(b) Figure III: Separated Extended Family Members by District of Birth

6.5 Table IV: Displacement Trajectories, Schooling, and Employment: Within-Family Estimates

Read:

- Table IV compares relatives within the same postwar household.
- For rural-born individuals, rural-to-rural IDPs and rural-to-urban IDPs retain positive education effects under household fixed effects.
- Some employment shifts survive, especially movement away from agriculture for urban-exposed trajectories.
- External displacement becomes less positive or negative, consistent with the weaker cross-sectional patterns.
- The estimates are robust to conflict-window restrictions and household-level controls in many cases.

Detailed interpretation: Table IV is crucial because it reduces family-level selection. If the schooling gains were only due to more ambitious or better-resourced families moving, the within-household coefficients would collapse. Their persistence suggests that displacement paths and destinations had independent effects on human capital. Still, within-family selection remains possible if families strategically moved particular children.

Economic message: The table strengthens the claim that wartime displacement altered educational trajectories, not merely that different families chose different paths.

TABLE IV
DISPLACEMENT TRAJECTORIES, SCHOOLING, AND EMPLOYMENT: WITHIN-FAMILY ESTIMATES

	Completed primary (dummy)				Agricultural employment			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Panel A: Born rural								
Externally displaced	-0.075** (0.007)	0.005 (0.008)	0.002 (0.010)	0.002 (0.012)	0.011* (0.006)	-0.068*** (0.016)	-0.065*** (0.018)	-0.083*** (0.024)
Intern. displ. rural → urban	0.136*** (0.015)	0.068*** (0.007)	0.060*** (0.009)	0.050*** (0.011)	-0.121*** (0.021)	-0.012 (0.007)	-0.011 (0.008)	-0.008 (0.011)
Intern. displ. rural → rural	-0.020*** (0.006)	0.028*** (0.007)	0.027*** (0.007)	0.027*** (0.008)	0.034*** (0.009)	-0.008 (0.006)	-0.012* (0.007)	-0.008 (0.010)
Mean non-displaced	0.251	0.251	0.253	0.258	0.821	0.821	0.827	0.824
Observations	70,401	70,401	54,754	39,286	27,192	27,192	20,615	14,830
No. of households	21,708	21,708	17,377	12,837	9,685	9,685	7,542	5,500
No. cluster admin-2 birth	128	128	128	128	128	128	128	125
No. cluster admin-2 res92	216	216	214	212	210	210	204	193
Panel B: Born urban								
Externally displaced	-0.043*** (0.003)	0.002 (0.016)	-0.004 (0.017)	-0.017 (0.016)	0.116** (0.047)	-0.036 (0.031)	-0.014 (0.030)	-0.037 (0.037)
Intern. displ. urban → rural	-0.096*** (0.014)	-0.014 (0.014)	-0.020 (0.013)	-0.020*** (0.013)	0.284*** (0.046)	-0.010 (0.046)	0.002 (0.019)	0.014 (0.020)
Intern. displ. urban → urban	0.052*** (0.003)	0.031*** (0.011)	0.028*** (0.013)	0.028*** (0.013)	-0.054*** (0.024)	-0.000 (0.046)	-0.003 (0.021)	-0.004 (0.024)
Mean non-displaced	0.490	0.490	0.496	0.502	0.430	0.430	0.428	0.424
Observations	34,473	34,473	28,792	25,324	6,834	6,834	5,243	4,478
No. of households	10,342	10,342	8,970	8,071	2,624	2,624	2,060	1,774

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TABLE IV
CONTINUED

	Completed primary (dummy)				Agricultural employment			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Sample age (years)	12–32	12–32	12–32	12–32	12–32	12–32	12–32	12–32
Conflict condition	All districts	All districts	Moved ± 1 year	Moved ± 0 year	All districts	All districts	Moved ± 1 year	Moved ± 0 year
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
District of birth fixed effects	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Household fixed effects	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
No. cluster admin-2 birth	88	88	87	87	87	87	85	84
No. cluster admin-2 res92	212	212	206	197	197	197	174	163

Notes: The table reports estimates associating schooling and employment outcomes with various displacement trajectories for individuals aged 12–32 in 1997 from households with separated young members. The dependent variable in columns (1)–(4) is an indicator taking the value of one if the individual completed primary education and zero otherwise, while in columns (5)–(8), the dependent variable takes the value of one if an individual is employed in agriculture and zero otherwise. The sample consists of young members (children, grandchildren, children-in-law, and other relatives) belonging to the same family, aged 12–32 years in 1997, who came from eight households (i.e., at least one child experienced a different displacement trajectory). In addition, we restrict to observations where the children were either displaced between 0–18 years (and not born abroad), or non-displaced. Columns (5) and (7) restrict the sample to those individuals that moved in a window of ± 1 year from a conflict event, while columns (6) and (8) focus on those individuals who moved during a conflict year. Panel A gives estimates across rural-born people. Externally displaced is an indicator that captures the externally displaced status (those who, in 1992, resided in neighbouring countries). Intern. displ. rural → urban is a variable that measures the urban displacement status (rural-born individuals who reside in urban regions in 1992) and Intern. displ. rural → rural is a variable that measures the rural to rural displacement status (rural-born individuals residing in a rural area outside their region of birth in 1992). Panel B gives estimates across urban-born individuals. Intern. displ. urban → rural is a variable that measures the urban to rural displacement status (urban-born residing in 1992 in rural regions) and Intern. displ. urban → urban is a variable that measures the urban to urban displacement status (urban-born residing in an urban region in 1992 outside their region of birth). Controls include a gender indicator, an indicator for the eldest children of the household head, age three effects, and district of birth fixed effects. The rural-urban classification follows the 1997 Mozambique census. Heteroskedasticity-adjusted standard errors clustered on two dimensions (admin-2 region of birth of child i and admin-2 region of residence in 1992 of child i) are reported in parentheses. * $p < .10$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$.

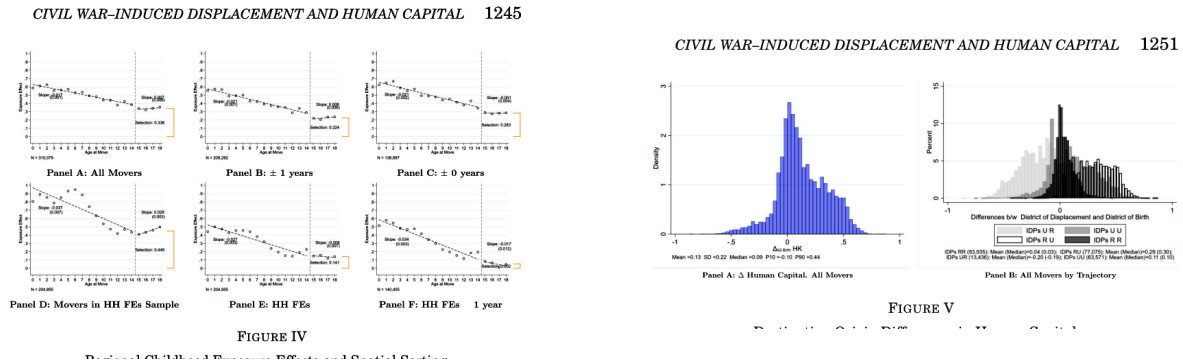
6.6 Figure IV: Regional Childhood Exposure Effects and Spatial Sorting

Read:

- Figure IV plots age-of-move coefficients on destination-minus-origin human-capital differences.
- For young movers, moving to a higher-schooling destination raises education more strongly.
- The slope attenuates with age and becomes more like sorting after age 15.
- Household fixed-effect panels show similar patterns, though noisier because the sample is smaller.
- Conflict-window restrictions reduce ordinary migration concerns and still show childhood exposure effects.

Detailed interpretation: Figure IV is the main place-effects figure. It shows that the effect of moving to a better destination depends on age at move. Earlier exposure matters more, which is exactly what a childhood human-capital mechanism predicts. Later movers reveal sorting because their primary schooling is mostly complete.

Economic message: Children do not simply carry fixed potential with them. Destination conditions during childhood can raise or lower schooling, even when moves are induced by civil war.



6.7 Figure V: Destination-Origin Differences in Human Capital

Read:

- Panel A shows the distribution of destination-origin schooling differences for all movers.
- Panel B decomposes those differences by trajectory.
- Rural-to-urban movers generally experience large positive destination-origin differences.
- Urban-to-rural movers often face negative destination-origin differences.
- Rural-to-rural movers often face smaller differences, making their positive schooling effects more suggestive of uprootedness or changed incentives.

Detailed interpretation: Figure V is a mechanism figure. It shows what types of destinations different trajectories reach. Rural-to-urban gains can be understood largely through better schooling environments. Rural-to-rural gains require more explanation because destination quality is often similar to the origin. Urban-to-rural moves help illustrate the downside of displacement into worse environments.

Economic message: Place quality is central, but not the entire story. Some displacement effects remain even when destination-origin schooling differences are small.

6.8 Table V: Place-Based Effects, Spatial Sorting, and Uprootedness: OLS, Reduced-Form, and IV Estimates

Read:

- Table V jointly estimates displacement, destination-origin differences, age windows, and instrumental-variable specifications.
- Young-age destination exposure has large positive effects when the destination has higher nonmover schooling.
- Spatial sorting remains important, especially for older movers and for actual destination-origin differences.
- The displaced indicator remains positive in many specifications, suggesting residual uprootedness effects.
- The IV estimates using prewar migration networks give similar qualitative results.

Detailed interpretation: Table V is the paper’s synthesis table. It decomposes the education effects into place effects, sorting, and uprootedness. The positive displaced coefficient after controls suggests that relocation itself can raise incentives for schooling, perhaps because land, local networks, and traditional agricultural livelihoods become less secure. The destination-origin interaction confirms that better places matter, especially for young children.

Economic message: Displacement is a bundle: it changes where children grow up, who moves where, and how households value portable human capital after being uprooted.

TABLE V
PLACE-BASED EFFECTS, SPATIAL SORTING, AND UPROOTEDNESS: OLS, REDUCED-FORM, AND IV ESTIMATES

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Panel A: Actual changes in O-D differences					
Displaced	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.017*** (0.004)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 0-4	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 5-9	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 10-14	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 15-19	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Panel B: Predicted changes in O-D differences					
Displaced	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.017*** (0.004)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 0-4	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 5-9	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 10-14	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 15-19	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)

TABLE V
CONTINUED

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Panel C: PSEs					
Displaced	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.017*** (0.004)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 0-4	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 5-9	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 10-14	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Δ 30 - Birth SES $\times$ AOWB 15-19	0.000*** (0.000)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Number of households	140,000	140,000	140,000	140,000	140,000
Observations	480,000	480,000	480,000	480,000	480,000
McLeod-Pearson P-Test	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000

TABLE V
CONTINUED

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Specifications						
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Displacement of birth fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Household fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
No. cluster admin 2 levels	210	210	210	210	210	210
No. cluster admin 3 levels	210	210	210	210	210	210

6.9 Table VI: IDPs and Rural-Born Stayers: Sibling Analysis, Upper-Primary School Completion + Table VII: Schooling, Social/Civic Capital, and Mental Health: Displaced Versus Urban Non-Movers

Read:

- Table VI compares IDPs in Nampula with siblings who stayed behind and focuses on upper-primary completion.
- The sibling comparison supports the census finding that displaced individuals can have higher education.
- Table VII compares displaced Nampula residents with urban-born nonmovers.
- The education coefficient in Table VII is statistically insignificant, suggesting educational catch-up relative to urban-born residents.
- Displaced respondents have lower trust, worse civic attitudes, lower optimism, and lower mental health.
- The mental-health and social-capital outcomes show that schooling gains do not imply overall welfare gains.

Detailed interpretation: These tables provide the paper’s most important welfare qualification. The census suggests human-capital gains, but the survey shows long-lasting psychosocial costs. IDPs can catch up educationally yet remain less trusting, less optimistic, and more psychologically distressed. This evidence prevents an overly optimistic reading of the education results.

Economic message: Forced displacement can simultaneously increase education and damage social integration and mental health. Policy should preserve schooling gains while addressing trauma and trust deficits.

TABLE VI
IDPs AND RURAL-BORN STAYERS: SIBLING ANALYSIS, UPPER-PRIMARY
SCHOOL COMPLETION

	Extended		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Moved during the war	0.230*** (0.054)	0.106* (0.061)	0.109* (0.062)
Controls	No	No	Yes
Household fixed effects	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	338	338	338
R-squared	0.041	0.499	0.508

Notes. The table reports linear probability model estimates, where the outcome variable is an indicator that takes the value of one if an individual has completed upper-primary schooling and zero otherwise. Moved during the war identifies 258 individuals displaced during the civil war, including 83 of the original respondents and 175 of their siblings. The omitted category consists of 80 respondents’ siblings, born in the countryside, who did not move during the war. Column (1) gives cross-sectional estimates; column (2) shows within-household specifications; column (3) also controls for age, gender, and whether the individual is the eldest offspring. Robust standard errors, adjusted for heteroskedasticity, are reported in parentheses. * $p < .10$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$.

TABLE VII
SCHOOLING, SOCIAL/CIVIC CAPITAL, AND MENTAL HEALTH: DISPLACED VERSUS URBAN NON-MOVERS

	Schooling	Trust	Social capital	Civic attitudes	Loneliness	Optimism	Mental health
Moved during the war	0.061 (0.067)	-0.462** (0.221)	-0.053 (0.178)	-0.596*** (0.186)	-0.159* (0.093)	-0.189*** (0.066)	-0.217** (0.102)
Observations	227	227	227	227	227	227	227
Non-mover mean	0.373	0.353	0.072	0.346	0.000	0.569	-0.000
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
R-squared	0.023	0.050	0.005	0.075	0.034	0.102	0.040

Notes. The table reports OLS estimates linking various outcomes to a Displaced indicator, which identifies respondents who moved during the civil war. The omitted category consists of residents of Nampula who were born in the city and never moved. In column (1), the dependent variable is a binary index that identifies respondents with completed upper-primary education (seven years). In column (2), the trust variable is constructed via principal components from responses on whether the respondent feels comfortable with a neighbor look after keys or children, reports a sense of belonging to the neighborhood, and trusts people in the neighborhood. In column (3), the social-capital index is a principal-component aggregate of willingness to give to good causes without expecting a return, unpaid community work in the past year, the importance placed on solving community problems, and willingness to exchange favors with neighbors. In column (4), the civic-attitudes index captures responses on whether it is justified to claim benefits, avoid taxes, or pay bribes. In column (5), the loneliness index is a principal-component aggregate of responses on whether a lack of companionship, have no one to turn to, feel alone, do not feel close to anyone, do not share interests with others, or feel isolated. In column (6), the optimism index measures expectations that children will be richer than the respondent at the same age. In column (7), the mental health index aggregates via principal components responses on whether in the previous two weeks respondents had little interest in activities, felt depressed, had trouble sleeping, felt tired, had appetite changes, felt like a failure, had difficulty concentrating, experienced shivers or restless movements, felt nervous, worried excessively, had trouble relaxing, felt restless or easily annoyed, or felt afraid. All specifications control for age, gender, and an eldest-offspring indicator. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < .10$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$.

(a) Table VI: Sibling Analysis, Upper-Primary Completion

(b) Table VII: Schooling, Social/Civic Capital, and Mental Health

7 Short summary

- The paper studies civil-war displacement in Mozambique using near-universe census data.
- It distinguishes external displacement, rural-to-urban IDPs, rural-to-rural IDPs, urban-to-rural movement, and urban-to-urban movement.
- Cross-sectional estimates show large gains for rural-to-urban IDPs and positive schooling effects for rural-to-rural IDPs.
- Within-household estimates reduce family selection concerns and preserve many positive effects for rural IDPs.
- Movers designs show that earlier childhood exposure to better districts raises schooling more than later exposure.
- Figure V and Table V show that destination quality, spatial sorting, and uprootedness all matter.
- Survey evidence in Nampula suggests educational gains persist, but trust, optimism, and mental health are lower among displaced people.
- The main lesson is that displacement is not one treatment. The destination, age of move, and postwar environment determine whether human capital rises or falls.

8 Expanded conclusion

8.1 Core conclusion

The paper shows that conflict-induced displacement can raise schooling and shift some people out of agriculture, especially when rural-born children move into towns or cities. This finding is surprising because civil war

is destructive and because displacement is usually understood mainly as a humanitarian catastrophe. The authors' contribution is to show that displacement can also act as a mobility shock that changes children's opportunity sets.

8.2 Economic intuition

The education effect comes from three channels. First, children may move to better places with more schools and nonfarm work. Second, families may sort across destinations depending on networks, ambition, wealth, or survival strategies. Third, the act of being uprooted may make portable human capital more valuable because land, kinship-based production, and local agricultural assets become less secure.

8.3 Why the result does not imply war is beneficial

The paper's results should not be interpreted as a positive view of war. The educational gains occur in a context of violence, mortality, forced movement, lost assets, family separation, and trauma. The survey results show that displaced people are less trusting, less optimistic, and report worse mental health decades later. The correct interpretation is that some displaced children gained access to schooling despite the war, not because the war was welfare-improving.

8.4 Mechanism interpretation

Rural-to-urban displacement is the clearest place-effect case: cities and towns had more schools and services. Rural-to-rural displacement is more subtle: gains there suggest that uprootedness and changed incentives matter even when destinations are not much better. Urban-to-rural displacement helps discipline the mechanism because moving from a high-human-capital origin to a lower-human-capital destination can reduce opportunities.

8.5 Policy implications

Humanitarian and postconflict policy should focus on destination conditions. If displaced children are likely to remain in host locations for years, schooling infrastructure, language support, transport, school-fee support, and psychosocial services are crucial. Urban receiving areas can become engines of human-capital accumulation if public services expand with population inflows. Conversely, refugee camps and rural host areas may need targeted schooling investments to avoid educational stagnation.

8.6 Implications for migration and development

The paper connects forced migration to the broader migration-development literature. Like voluntary migration, forced displacement can expose children to better institutions and schools. Unlike voluntary migration, it comes with violence, trauma, and limited choice. This makes it especially important to distinguish destination effects from welfare effects.

8.7 Limitations

The census observes survivors in 1997 and reconstructs wartime trajectories from residence in 1992 and 1997. Mortality, postwar return migration, and household formation may affect estimates. Within-household designs cannot rule out all within-family selection. The Nampula survey is small and localized. Still, the convergence of multiple designs makes the education result credible.

8.8 Final takeaway

Displacement is a bundled treatment: it changes place, family networks, assets, incentives, and trauma. The paper's most important lesson is that the human-capital consequences of forced movement depend on where people move, when in childhood they move, and whether receiving areas can turn displacement into access to schooling rather than prolonged marginalization.